

See Tactical Patterns

Recognize a fork, pin or skewer, then prove that the geometry actually works.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 A fork must come with time

P. 3

02 A pin restricts particular moves

P. 6

03 A skewer needs a clear line

P. 9

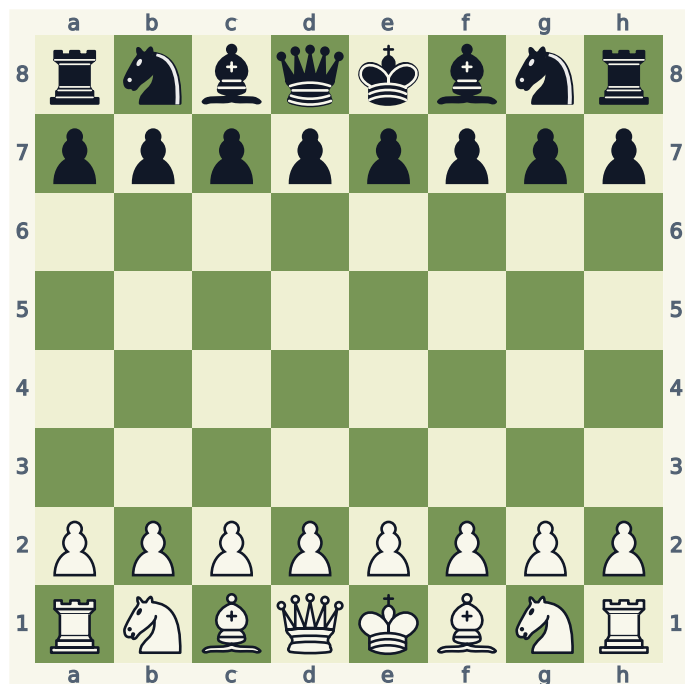
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

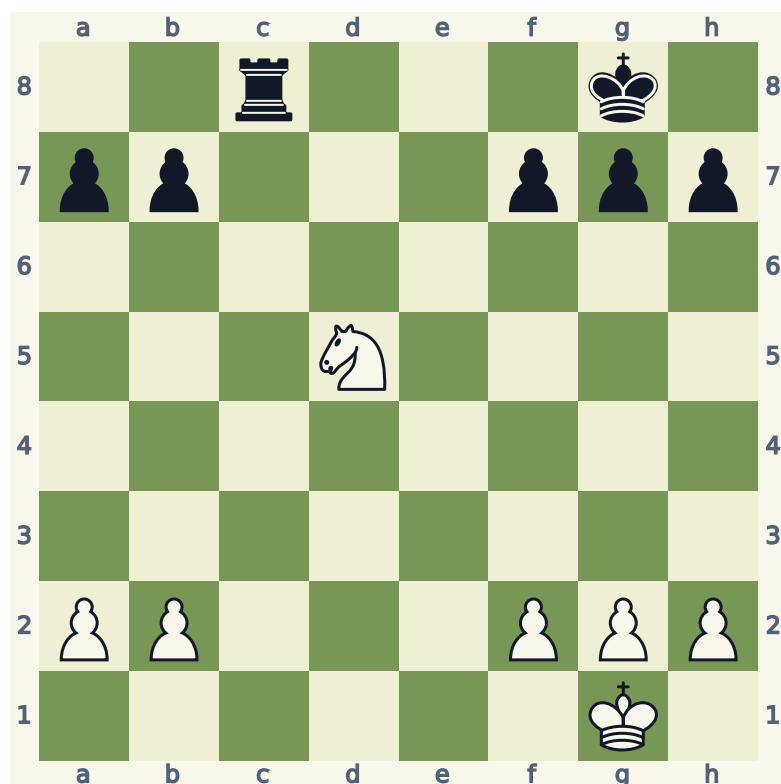
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

A fork must come with time

A knight fork attacks two targets. When one target is the king, the opponent must answer the check, often leaving no time to save the other target.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. The knight on d5 can jump to e7.
2. From e7 it attacks the king on g8 and the rook on c8.
3. No black piece can capture the knight on e7 in response to the check.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Ne7+ Kf8 2. Nxc8

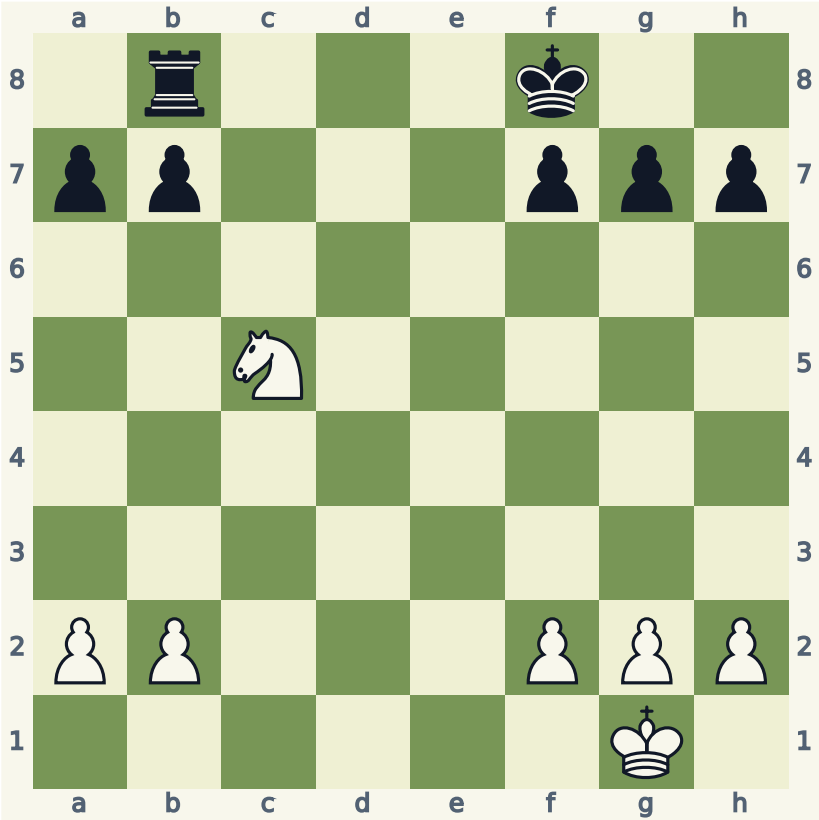
Ne7+ makes a double attack with check. Black must move the king; ...Kf8 is one legal reply. The knight then takes the rook with Nxc8.

Check the landing square before celebrating the pattern. A fork fails if the forking piece can be captured, if the second target moves with check, or if the first target can answer while saving the second. Here the king cannot capture the knight, and the rook cannot remove the check.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- Find a knight move that attacks the king and rook at the same time.
- Give a legal king reply, followed by the knight's capture.
- Why does Black not have time to move the rook first?

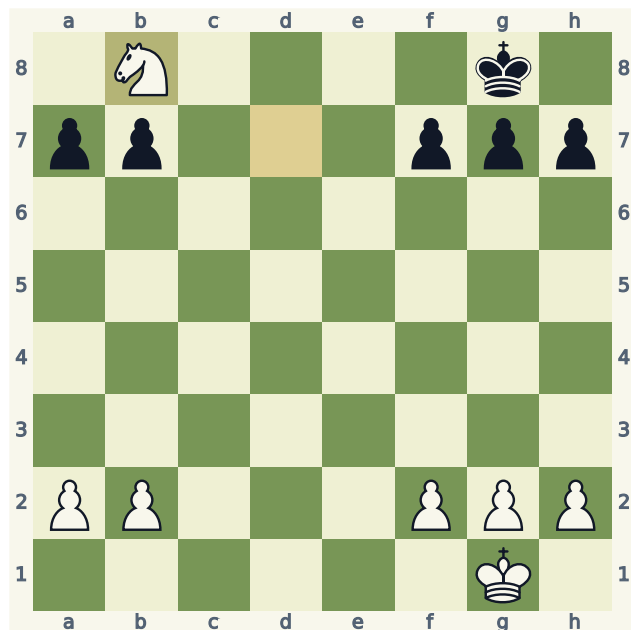
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 1r3k2/pp3ppp/8/2N5/8/8/PP3PPP/6K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Nd7+ Kg8 2. Nxb8

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. Nd7+ attacks f8 and b8 from d7. The board has shifted, so use the knight's actual L-shaped moves rather than remembering e7 from Model A.

2. After ...Kg8, Nxb8 captures the rook. Other legal king moves still leave the rook forked. Check that no black pawn attacks the knight's landing square d7.

3. The king is in check. A rook move that does not capture the knight or otherwise remove the knight check is illegal. The checking component supplies the time needed to collect the second target.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

A diagram that resembles a fork is only a suggestion. Name both attacked squares, inspect captures of the knight, and calculate one move beyond the apparent win.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

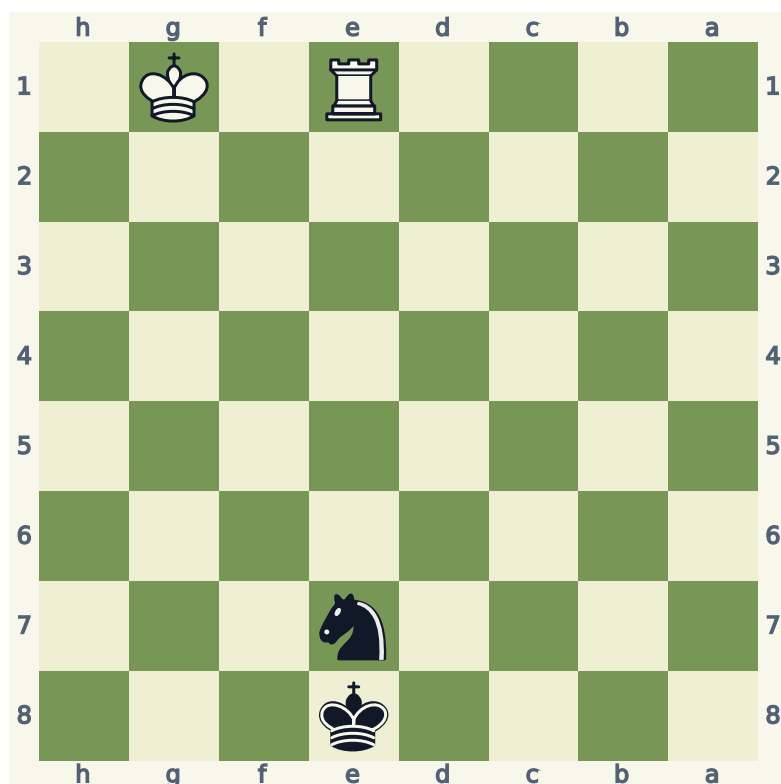
On an empty board, place a knight on d4 and name all eight attacked squares. Then place a king and rook on two of those squares and test whether the fork is legal.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

A pin restricts particular moves

An absolute pin forbids moves that expose your king to check. It does not freeze a piece by a special rule; normal king-safety rules determine exactly which moves remain legal.

MODEL A / BLACK TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's rook on e1 points at the black king on e8.
2. The black knight on e7 is the only piece blocking that line.
3. Every knight move would leave the e-file, exposing the king.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1... Kf7

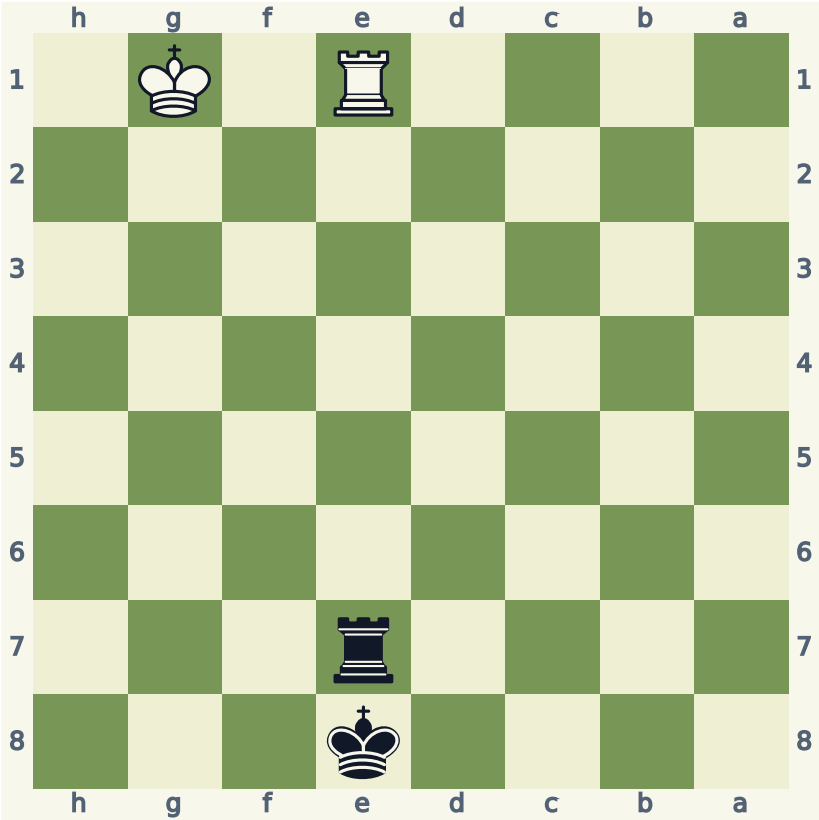
Black cannot move the knight while the king stays on e8 and the pin remains. A knight cannot slide along the pin line, so all of its jumps would uncover a rook check on its own king.

...Kf7 is a legal way to step out of the pin. This is a rule demonstration, not a claim that Black can save the ending against best play. Once the king is off the e-file, moving the knight no longer exposes that particular check.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / BLACK TO MOVE



1. What piece replaced the pinned knight?
2. Is ...Rxe1+ legal? Trace the rook's entire path.
3. State a precise rule that works for both diagrams.

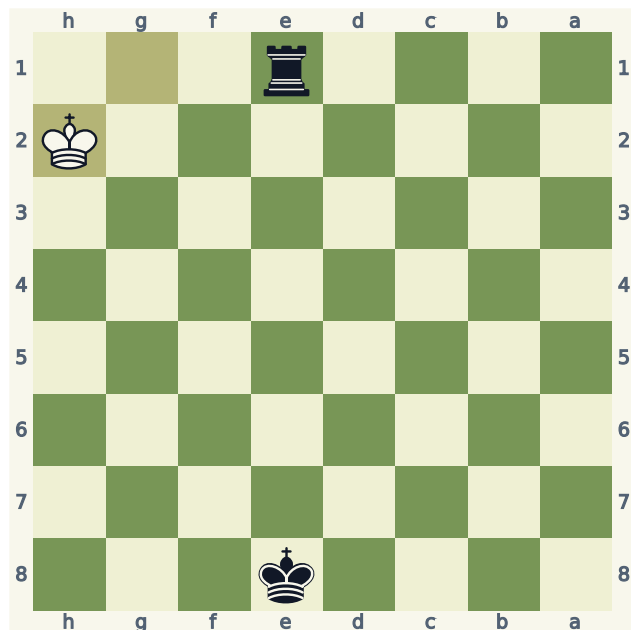
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 4k3/4r3/8/8/8/8/4R1K1 b - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1... Rxe1+ 2. Kh2

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. A black rook now stands on e7. Unlike a knight, a rook can move along the e-file and remain between the white rook and its king.

2. Yes. The squares e6 through e2 are empty. ...Rxe1+ captures the pinning rook and removes the threat to the black king. It also checks White along the first rank; Kh2 is a legal reply.

3. A move is illegal if it leaves your own king in check. A pinned slider may move along the pin line or capture the attacker if the resulting king position is safe. "A pinned piece cannot move" is an unreliable shortcut.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Pinned pieces still occupy and attack squares. For king moves, a square attacked by a pinned piece is still treated as attacked. Do not let your king capture a defended piece just because its defender is pinned.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

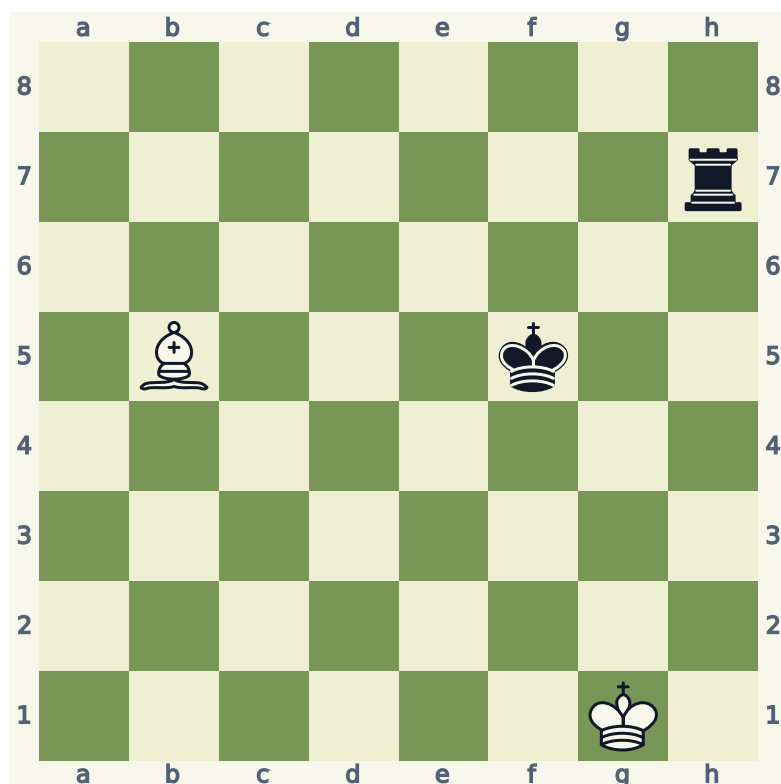
Set up a rook pin, then replace the pinned piece with a knight, bishop and rook. For each, list legal moves instead of assuming the answer is unchanged.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

A skewer needs a clear line

A skewer attacks a valuable front piece and exposes a target behind it. The line must be clear both when the attack begins and after the front piece moves.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. The bishop can travel from b5 through c4 to d3.
2. From d3, the diagonal d3-e4-f5-g6-h7 contains Black's king and rook.
3. The black king must leave the diagonal when checked.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Bd3+ Ke5 2. Bxh7

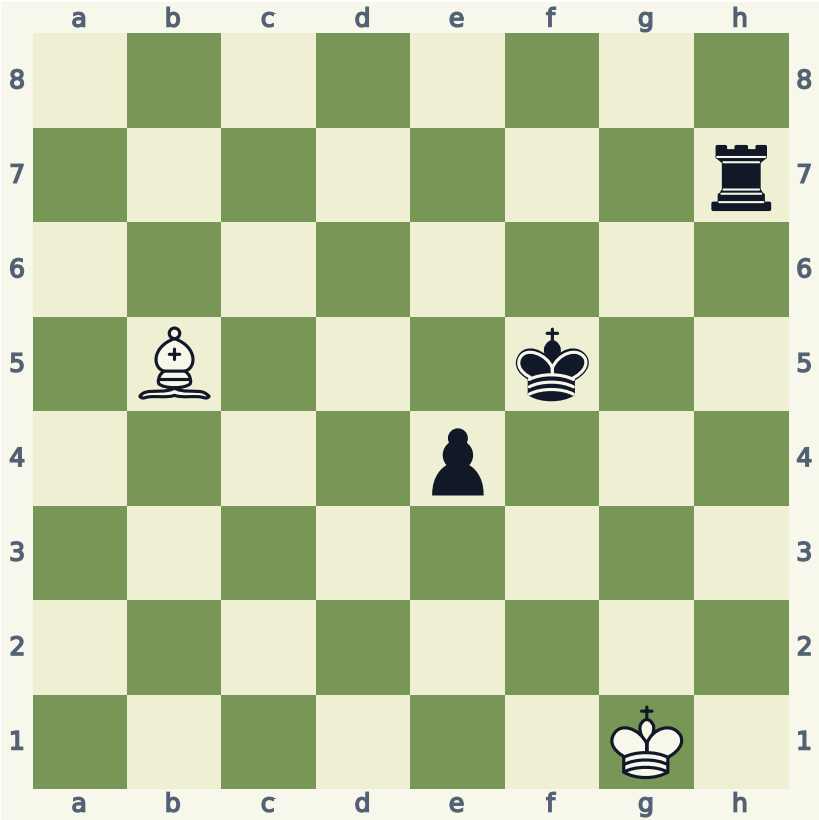
Bd3+ checks the king on f5. After the illustrative ...Ke5, the bishop takes the rook with Bxh7. The king cannot move onto g6, because the bishop also attacks that square.

Distinguish the geometry: in a pin the protected target is behind the piece that is restricted; in this skewer the king is the front target and must move, exposing the rook. The resulting capture follows from an open diagonal, not from the pattern's name.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. What does the added pawn on e4 do to the diagonal?
2. Is Bd3 check? Calculate Black's simplest reply.
3. Give a legal bishop move that avoids losing it to that pawn.

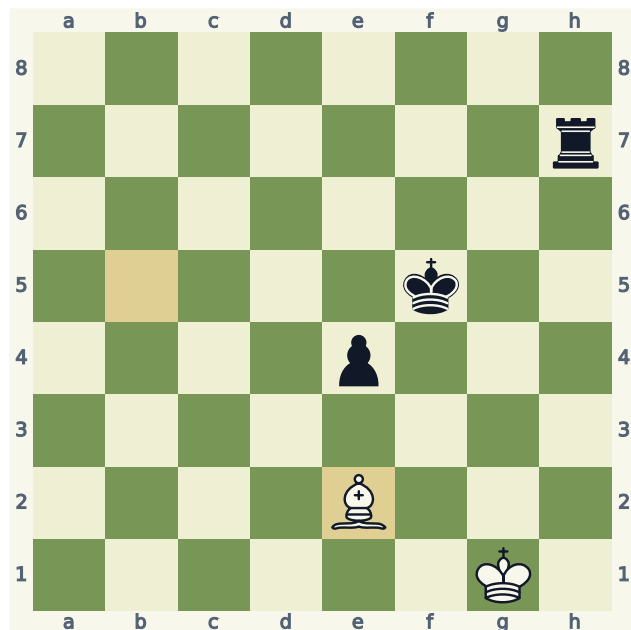
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 8/7r/8/1B3k2/4p3/8/8/6K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Be2

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The e4-pawn interrupts d3-e4-f5-g6-h7 before the line reaches the king. The bishop no longer attacks the king through that square.

2. Bd3 is not check, and ...exd3 captures the bishop. A black pawn on e4 attacks d3. White has mistaken a blocked line for the skewer in Model A.

3. Be2 is a safe example: b5-c4-d3-e2 is a clear route, and the bishop ends beyond the pawn's attacks. This does not claim White wins the rook ending; it answers the narrower question of preserving the bishop.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Before moving a bishop onto an attacking diagonal, trace every intervening square. A pawn may block the line and may also capture the bishop on its proposed square.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

When you spot a bishop tactic, read the whole diagonal aloud, including empty squares. Then ask what can capture the bishop on its new square.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. What must you test before trusting a knight fork?
2. Can a pinned rook capture the rook pinning it?
3. Why does adding a pawn on e4 refute Bd3 in this example?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. Whether the landing square is safe, whether both targets are attacked, and whether the reply can remove the check while saving material.
2. Yes, if the path is clear and the capture leaves its own king safe.
3. It blocks the check to f5 and can capture the bishop with ...exd3.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

Lichess practice: tactics and endgames

Lichess opposition practice

Lichess basic rook endgames

Stockfish: official engine

Lichess tablebase API

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.